PAD 306: TRADITIONAL ADMINISTRATIVE SYSTEM IN NIGERIA

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TRADITIONAL FORMS OF GOVERNMENT IN AFRICA

African societies, throughout the centuries, have been organized on the basis of a social contract whereby people come together to form a state or nation because they believe that, through their combined efforts, they will be more able to realize their common aspirations for peace and security, which are essential for their physical and spiritual welfare and progress, both as individuals and as a community. It is to achieve these objectives that the people agree collectively to surrender to a king or ruler the power to control their lives and to organize and regulate activities within their society. In the process, they have always had clear understandings and agreements regarding the ideas and principles that underlie their political systems and on the basis of which power and authority are to be exercised by the various elements of government.

By traditional systems, I refer to genuine traditional institutions, uncontaminated by colonial or post-independence modifications or distortions. Most observers of traditional African political systems recognize two main forms, namely the non-centralized or fragmented traditional state and the centralized state.

Non-centralized traditional states: In these states, there was no sovereign in the Austinian sense. Techniques of social control revolved around what Meyer Fortes called the "dynamics of clanship". The normative scheme consisted of elaborate bodies of well- established rules of conduct, usually enforced by heads of fragmented segments, and in more serious or subversive cases, by spontaneous community action. Examples are the "Tallensi" of Northern Ghana, the Sukuma of Tanzania, the Nuer of Southern Sudan, the Ibos of Nigeria and the Kikuyu of Kenya. For the purposes of our discussion we should note two major features of this system:

1. The existence of well-defined norms despite the absence of a hierarchical system headed by a sovereign;

2. The direct and pronounced participation of people-members of clans, segments and so on in decision making assuring a visible democratic process.

Centralized States: The centralized states such as Asante and Mole - Dabgani of Ghana, Yorubaland of Nigeria, Zulus of South Africa, Barotse of Zambia and Baganda of Uganda had a more structured and sophisticated political system. These states were organized under well-entrenched, highly structured and sophisticated political authorities. They had all the elements of an Austinian state- a political sovereign backed by well-organized law enforcement agencies and habitually obeyed by the citizenry. Infraction of well-articulated legal norms attracted swift sanctions imposed by state officials. But the king, chief or the political sovereign, ruled with his council of elders and advisors in accordance

with the law, and although autocracy was not unknown, the rule of law was a cardinal feature of their system of governance. The king was ultimately accountable and liable to deposition upon the violation of norms considered subversive of the entire political system or particularly heinous.

In many cases the political structures were complemented by hierarchy of courts presided over by the king, the head chief or the village chief. The concept of law in these states was, in substance, hardly distinguishaole from that of a modem state. In most of these states, there was provision for participation in decision-making by groups of the citizenry either indirectly through the heads of their clans' lineages or families; or more directly through various types of organizations like the Asafo Companies of the Fantes in Ghana.

Eligibility for installation as king or chief was limited to certain royal families but among many states of Ghana the institution of king-makers was not unlike the Electoral College in some other countries. The Queen mother played a critical role as the custodian of the "royal register" and the person who pronounced on the eligibility of conditions for chiefly office.

MULTIPLICITY OF SYSTEMS

It is evident from the theme of this Session and my remarks that there are various systems of traditional governance in Africa. Just as there have been and remain different forms and orientations of western democracy, so there were different forms and institutions of government among the various ethnic groups and societies in different parts of Africa. But, in spite of the unavoidable variations, the different forms of African traditional governance had a number of important common elements and features:

Invariably, they almost always involve the devolution of power by ascription. A person inherits governmental authority or position mainly by virtue of membership of a particular family or clan. However, in many cases, the choice of the political leader is based not solely on the circumstance of birth, but involves other criteria, such as the character or other personal qualities. Where this is the case, there usually is an election between several eligible persons from the same family or clan. The people who exercised governmental authority were referred to by various names in different parts of Africa, such as kings, chiefs, elders, leopard skin chiefs, emirs and so on. In all cases, they ruled or governed their societies with the assistance of lower-rank rulers, as well as a large number and levels of advisers who for the most part also occupied their positions by virtue of their family or clan origins and status.

It is worth emphasizing that this mechanism ensures that the king or chief does not rule arbitrarily. Although the king or chief has the final word, he is bound to consult very regularly, and decisions are reached by consensus without formal votes. In this connection, although a chief is elected and installed for life, his continued stay in office is subject to good conduct.

A chief who breaks his oath of office to seek the welfare of the people and progress of the nation is removable according to the rules and procedures laid down and transmitted from generation to generation. It is not my intention to glorify our traditional systems. But I am concerned to point out that democracy was not alien to all traditional African systems, and the rule of law, which provided checks and balances in the political system and imposed restraints on authoritarian rule, was a prominent feature of most traditional African systems.

THE FUNTIONS OF THE TRADITIONAL RULEP

Before the advent of colonial rule, the traditional leader's role encompassed numerous functions, which revolved around the cardinal theme of guiding, protecting, defending and providing for the needs of the society he served. He was the intermediate between the departed ancestors, the living and the yet unborn. These holistic approaches involved religious, military, legislative, executive, judicial, social and cultural features.

Leadership was however predicated on a set of well-articulated norms and mechanisms. The multifarious functions were exercised with specific functionaries whose role was hallowed by ancient custom. Sometimes these were elders or councilors, or communal groups or judicial institutions or state or drummers. Each entity performed its assigned role in accordance with customary law.

The military role of the traditional leader was accentuated by the frequent incidence of inter-ethnic wars or the normal process of acquiring territory for statehood. But in this function, the welfare of the people was paramount. Any chief who ignored this forfeited the trust of his people and was liable to deposition.

TRADITIONAL AUTHORITY IN COLONIAL AND POST COLONIAL ERAS

The colonial and post-independence eras had a profound impact on traditional institutions, in particular chieftaincy. The colonial system ostensibly enhanced chieftaincy through the system of indirect rule particularly in Nigeria. But the perception that chiefs and kings ultimately derived their power from the colonial power eventually undermined their power. In some African countries the colonial

authorities appointed chiefs directly thereby underscoring the uncomfortable fact that they were colonial creations, which were ultimately abolished with the demise of colonial rule.

As far as post-colonial African regimes were concerned, it is hardly contestable that they saw traditional authorities as a dangerous bastion of rival political power and largely succeeded in dismantling or attenuating their authority. The reality is that in most African states our traditional systems have been divested of their formal executive, economic and judicial powers except in narrowly defined areas. Even more critical, they have been denied the requisite resources for effective functioning, although the institution of chieftaincy has been guaranteed in some constitutions such as Ghana's.

But, in spite of all these moves, it is paradoxical that in a number of African countries, chieftaincy is attracting academics, civil servants, business leaders and teachers. In Nigeria, the traditional leadership position is becoming more competitive than probably ever before.

TRADITIONAL AUTHORITY TODAY

Admittedly, the chief of today cannot act in the way his predecessors acted. He is neither the military leader nor the legislator that he once was. Except in very limited areas, he has no judicial functions or executive powers of any significance. But this does not mean that the chief has no meaningful role in the modern era.

On the contrary, he has a vital role to play not just in his own domain, but also at the national level. This fact is recognized in the governmental system of Ghana, where the institution of chieftaincy is given an entrenched status in the 1992 Constitution. Among other duties, chiefs are expected to provide advice to the central government and to participate in the administration of regions and districts.

Apart from these constitutional functions, chiefs have the moral obligation to contribute to the lives of their individual citizens in particular, and to the nationals of their country. These days, a chief is expected to lead his people in organizing self-help activities and projects, and take the initiative in establishing institutions and programmes to improve the welfare of his people in areas such as health, educational, trade and economic or social development. These institutions and programmes are not intended to replace those that must be provided by the central and regional government, but rather to supplement them, especially in these days when the demands of the people are such that it is unrealistic to expect that they can all be met from central government resources. The chiefs can and do play a vital role in development, which at once enhances democracy and sustains good governance.

The developmental roles of chiefs include mobilizing their people for the execution of development projects, sensitizing them to health hazards, promoting education, preaching -discipline, encouraging various economic enterprises, inspiring respect for the law and urging the people to participate in the electoral process. Most of these efforts are done without formal recognition or financial support from Government. Modern African states have not all succeeded in establishing viable insurance schemes, comprehensive health and educational systems, facilities for counseling the youth or role models in all fields of endeavor.

The modern chief, stripped of political and executive power and formal financial support, has to address these basic needs for his people using his ingenuity, diplomacy, power of motivation and sometimes his own personal resources.

Chiefs have been most active in dispute resolution both in Africa generally and in Nigeria particularly, where parties, disenchanted with the dilatory procedures of the formal courts, have clamoured for traditional techniques of resolution. Indeed dispute resolution would have been impossible without the active involvement of chiefs in all parts of Nigeria.

Diversity and transformation of African traditional institutions

Nigerian traditional institutions of governance are diverse. They have evolved significantly from their pre-colonial forms in tandem with transformation of the continent's political systems, during the colonial and post-colonial eras. Despite their complex diversity, much of the post-independence literature classifies Nigerian traditional institutions of governance into two types, based on their pre-colonial forms:

(a) the consensus-based systems of the decentralized pre-colonial political systems; and

(b) chieftaincy of the centralized political systems.

• ***Decentralized systems***

In large parts of Nigeria, pre-colonial political systems were highly decentralized with law-making, social control, and allocation of resources carried out by local entities, such as lineage groupings, village communities, and age-sets. These systems were largely based on consensual decision-making arrangements that varied from one place to another.

The fundamental principles that guide the consensus based (decentralized authority) systems include curbing the concentration of power in an institution or a person and averting the emergence of a rigid hierarchy. The settlement of conflicts and disputes in such consensual systems involves narrowing of differences through negotiations rather than through adversarial procedures that produce -winners and losers.

INTRODUCTION

In contemporary Africa the mode of governance is undoubtedly influenced by Western values and ideals, but the majority of African citizens value their indigenous culture. The importance of indigenous culture is seen in the food they eat, the languages they continue to speak and even the way they dress. It is, however, not completely clear as to the nature and to what extent indigenous culture influences governance practices in contemporary Africa. Furthermore, if indigenous culture plays a role in governance, what are the implications of that for socioeconomic development and democracy?

An *Economist* article entitled ("African Democracy," n.d) claims that there are eleven countries with flawed democracies, sixteen hybrid states, eighteen authoritarian regimes and one failed state on the continent of Africa. In the article, Africa is labeled as practicing a flawed democracy based on the five indices created by the Economist Intelligence Unit. These indices are electoral process and pluralism, civil liberties, functioning of government, political participation and political culture. While these indices are useful as an analytical device they do not directly address African traditions or indigenous culture and how these may impinge upon or interact with democratic practices in Africa. The coexistence of tradition (indigenous culture) and "modernity" (western traditions), and its implications for effective democracy and attendant economic development require a careful examination.

The term "indigenous" according to Dei (2000) is defined as knowledge consciousness arising locally and in association with long-term occupancy of a place. In Africa many ethnic groups have different forms of governance; nonetheless the features of the African indigenous political system go hand in hand with Williams' (1987) "African constitution." They are as follows:

1. Building blocks of government are the people
2. Decisions are made by public opinion
3. Checks and balances are implemented to curb despotism.
4. Decentralization of the political system
5. Freedom of Expression
6. Decision-making by consensus
7. Participatory democracy

It is often presented to or believed by contemporary Africans the birth of democracy is credited to the "West" and often traced back to the Greeks. While this is historically true, Tiky (2014) in his book *Democracy and Democratization in Africa* looks back into history to ask where the Greeks learnt about democracy. Tiky (2014) concludes that Solon (594-3), an Athenian who launched the reforms that gave birth to the Athenian democracy, made numerous trips to Egypt where he learnt about the African political system. This is confirmed by Diodorus Siculus, a Greek writer of the 1st century who acknowledged that Solon, Pythagoras and Homer made trips to Egypt to learn about politics, mathematics and religion. Based on these reported travels Tiky (2014) argues that since Egypt is the oldest civilization known to man, one can attribute the birthplace of democracy to Africa.

Ayittey (1999) offers the same assertion but in a different way; he posits that democracy is not owned by one culture or race but is practiced differently through different institutions. One example is in the making of a decision by majority vote versus consensus decision. Hence African empires, kingdoms, states and stateless societies practiced versions of democracy prior to European contact. It can thus be argued that pre-colonial Africa adopted governing systems that were democratic in nature, allowing citizens, empires, and kingdoms to flourish. It is important to highlight and explain the seven characteristics used to describe indigenous governance.

1. *Building blocks of government are the people*

Governance in pre-colonial Africa started and ended with the people, the citizens and everyone who lived in the village. The basis of African socio-political thought started with what Bell (2002) calls the "village palaver," where decisions were made for the purpose of unity, to ensure that the community moved from injustice to justice; wrong to right; brokenness to wholeness and ignorance to truth. This practice is captured in the concept of communalism. This type of communal decision making led by citizens was evident in all traditional societies such as the Ashanti of Ghana (Asetena kese), Igbo of Nigeria (ama-ala), Shir among the Somali, Tswana of Botswana (kyotla), Shona of Zimbabwe (dare), Xhosa (pitso) and Zulu of South Africa (ndaba). It was at village assemblies/palavers where everyone came to express individuality within the framework of the community; this is why Gyekye (1987) calls African societies amphibious, because the governance practices manifest features of both communality and individuality.

2. *Decisions made by public opinion*

The communal belief system, which is described above, served as the basis for decision-making. Thus kings, chiefs and elders were responsible to the people and vice versa. Before any chief or king was enstooled, they were to swear an oath, which served as a binding contract between the people and the leader. It is this oath that created accountability and transparency between traditional leaders and citizens. It is in the context of this contract that people/citizens were in principle and practice final judges on issues, which affected their community or society.

3. *Checks and balances*

African political systems during the pre-colonial era knew about the dangers of allowing a traditional leader to attain uncontrolled power. There are various examples where chiefs were surrounded by numerous institutions, which served as checks on their powers. These institutional mechanisms of checks and balances manifested themselves in three forms: religious, institutionalized, and spontaneous (p. 126).

Ayittey (1991) points out that, under the religious type of checks and balances, as the guardian of the people the chief/king served as a bridge between the ancestors of the lands and the people. This duty which is explicitly stated when the chief swore his oath during enstoolment

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enjoins him to ensure the safety and wellbeing of his people, and so as to be pleasing to the ancestors. This transcendental responsibility, which is part of traditions among indigenous leaders of the Akans of Ghana, the Yoruba of Nigeria, and the Limba of Sierra Leone, by its very nature constrains the actions of such leaders/rulers.

In terms of institutionalized checks and balances, this took the form of private and public admonitions from the Queen Mother, the Inner or Privy Council of Advisers and the Council of Elders. If a chief/king did not listen to these entities there was a possibility of destoolment. For example, the Asante people destooled three kings - Osei Kwame in 1799 for absenting himself from Kumasi and failing to perform his religious duties during the Adae festivals; Kariki in 1874 for extravagance; and Mensa Bonsu in 1883 for excessively taxing the Asante people.

If religious and institutional checks and balances failed, spontaneous actions were available such as what the Akan peoples of Ghana call rebellion (adom ye); the Yoruba of Nigeria call kirikiri; and the Gikuyu of Kenya call itwika.

4. *Decentralization of the political system*

All African kingdoms from Egypt to Monomotapa, Lunda, Ghana as well as Mali and Songhai were states that comprised multiple municipalities, which explain the relation between kinship and representative democracy. Two facts stand out clearly: first, that decentralization was the dominant feature of the African kingdoms, and secondly, that the old family, clan and tribal organization survived in the new regime, which was ever striving to make territorial considerations, and not the incident of kinship, the basis of state control.

Decentralization was a fundamental principle for African political organization, since it allowed for diffusion of power across the polity, encouraged participation, inclusion, and fostered an attitude of power sharing. The sheer sizes of some of the empires and kingdoms during the pre-colonial era meant the most effective mode of governance was through decentralization where authority and responsibilities would be in the hands of local authorities. Practicing this mode of devolution of authority, local communities enjoyed substantial autonomy to run their own affairs, hence, the presence of over 2000 distinct tribes present in Africa today.

5. *Freedom of Expression*

At the core of the African Social Order is what Gyekye (1987) calls communalism, which he defines as the doctrine that a group or society constitutes the focus of the activities of the individual members of society. It is this central feature of society that allows everyone in the community the right to voice his/her opinion without fear of reprisal. This phenomenon is consistent with Williams' (1987) summary of the fundamental rights of the African people:

- The right to equal protection of the law
- The right to criticize and condemn any acts by the authorities or proposed new laws
- The right to reject the community's final decision on any matter and to withdraw from the community unmolested - the right of rebellion and withdrawal.

- The right to an equal share in all benefits from common community undertakings if one has contributed to the fullest extent of his ability, no matter who or how many were able to contribute more. (Williams, 1987, p. 174-175)

Furthermore, Tiky (2014) draws on the work by Claude Welch (1984) who states that precolonial states recognized six major sets of rights; right to life, right to education, right to freedom of movement, right to receive justice, right to work and right to participate in the benefits and decision-making of the community. One example is the establishment of the Mali Empire in 1236 by Sundiata Keita, which involved the Kurukan Fuga Charter. With 44 articles the Charter described how the empire would operate politically, socially, environmentally, and economically. Consequently, Tribes such as the Igbo, Yoruba, Ga, Asante and Abesheini, fiercely defended the right to free speech.

6. *Decision-making by consensus*

Based on the African philosophical thought of interconnectedness and sacredness of the land and people, decisions at village meetings were made by consensus. The premise of making decisions through consensus was to ensure minority positions were heard and also taken into account. Consensus building brought about unity the downside was the length of time it took to make decisions. It took days and sometimes weeks to come to a decision.

The idea of consensual democracy is an African feature, which ensures the community is unified within the context of the individuals that belong to the community. In practice this may have involved a chief facilitating a debate about legislation within the Inner Council and Council of Elders. If unanimity was not reached the chief would request a village assembly where deliberations took place in order to reach a consensus. This motif is the motivation for keeping the community alive through consensus decision-making.

7. *Participatory democracy*

The village palaver formed the basis of African civil society, and provided the space for local and participatory democracy. With an open form of decision-making along with representation through kinship, the indigenous system of government was unique, open and inclusive. It is this system that brought together all the characteristics mentioned above; where an open village palaver made decisions through rational dialogue, to empower individuals and to bring the community together.

The features of indigenous governance explained above serve as the framework for describing and measuring indigenous governance. The commonalities of the epistemologies and principles that historically were used to govern different societies in Africa are as follows:

1. The people are the first and final source of all power.
2. The rights of the community of people are, and of right ought to be, superior to those of any individual, including Chiefs and Kings.
   (a) The Will of the people is the supreme law.
   (b) Chiefs and Kings are under the law, not above it.

3. Kings, Chiefs and Elders are leaders, not rulers. They are the elected representatives of the people and the instruments for executing their will.
4. Government and people are one and the same.
5. The family is recognized as the primary social, judicial, economic and political unit in the society.
6. The land belongs to no one. It is God's gift to mankind for use and as a sacred heritage, transmitted by our forefathers as a bond between the living and the dead to be held in trust by each generation for the unborn who will follow, and thus to the last generation (Williams, 1987, p. 171).

Williams (1987) lists 15 more customs, which guided the people who are at the center of decision-making. These customs are what Williams (1987) describes as traditional governing structures focused on creating a collective consciousness through communality, collectivity and co-operation. In addition, Nketsia (2013) notes that it was people power that endowed the leader and members of the community with duties of responsibility, relatedness and respect. The idea of people being the government provides the ontological framework for ensuring people lived the constitution as opposed to abiding by the constitution.

When the Europeans arrived on the continent, colonization diverted and in some cases truncated indigenous ways in which Africa governed itself. This period was further complicated by the so-called "Scramble for Africa" during, and after, the Berlin Conference of 1884. At this conference the major European powers arbitrarily divided Africa into colonies that they ruled directly and dictatorially (Davidson, 1998, p. 233).

The issue of colonization is inextricably linked to the idea of Western/liberal democracy. To understand the linkage we must look at the epistemological basis of Western/liberal democracy. Barber (1984) contends that Western/liberal democracy is, in fact, undemocratic. His argument is based in the epistemological theories set forth by liberal democrats themselves, including Thomas Hobbes and John Locke. Barber (1984) notes that such epistemological theories end up being anarchist, realist and minimalist.

Anarchist theory comes from the belief that men and women are free and autonomous with needs and wants that can be achieved outside of coercive communities. The premise of this belief is that men and women who have their liberty can achieve anything, which in politics means power. Hence the realm of governance has to do with obtaining power to enact individual political will. The expression of individual will over and above the needs of the collective is what gives rise to the advancement of privacy, liberty, individualism, and property rights.

Along with anarchism giving rise to power, Barber (1984) explains that realist theory explain the exercise of power of free men and women. In the exercising of accumulated power and th satisfying of needs and wants, the process of enacting political will over others require

manipulation, enforcement, deterrence, incentive and sanctions. The realist mantra, then, is "one man's freedom is the next man's bondage." Free men and women with power become power keepers as opposed to power sharers.

The third theory Barber (1984) employs to explain why Western/liberal democracy is undemocratic is minimalist theory. It aims to address the issues that arise as a result of anarchy and realism: with anarchism people want power, which leads to realism in which people use the power they gain. Minimalist theory propounds that the only way to protect others against the free man or woman with enormous power is tolerance, which advocates skepticism and wariness of the need of power and limits on power. In the political realm, skeptical minimalism gives rise to the implementation of individual rights which subsequently limit the rights of others and spell the end of collectivism.

For Barber (1984), Western/ liberal democracies create societies in which free men and women become their own enemies. While they are free to gain power they are subject to being "caged". The process of "caging" is called "political zoology," a process by which free men and women are admired for their individuality and for their unshackled freedom but cannot be admired because they are not trustworthy, are dangerous and are antisocial. In this framework of "political zoology," Western/liberal democracy is exposed as a process that is undemocratic because it abhors participation, political activity and citizenship. Thus Barber (1984) calls Western/liberal democracy "thin democracy".

Having briefly covered the epistemological frameworks of pre-colonial African democracy and Western/Liberal democracy from the perspective of Barber (1984), we can see the difference in how democracy has been practiced and how it has been exercised. Traditional African democracy was practiced and exercised throughout the lives of individuals who comprised the community; hence the people were the government. On the other hand, Western/liberal democracy has been practiced and exercised through rational institutions which prevent/dissuade individuals from being completely social beings. This distinction is very important because it suggests there can be different forms of democracy.

On arrival in Africa, the colonizers were familiar with their form of democracy (the orange), so when they were exposed to various forms of African democracy (the apple), they failed to recognize, respect and understand it. As such, efforts were made to make the "apple" extinct and the "orange" imposed throughout the continent. The extinction of African democracy (the apple) was achieved through the process of colonization, or the anarchism, realism and minimalism that Barber (1984) calls liberal democracy. Through this process, Africans were robbed of their cultural framework of governance, and thus from 1830 until about 1960 there was continual struggle by African nations to regain their sovereignty. In fighting for their independence from colonial powers, many Africans had no choice but to learn ideas and principles of Western/liberal democracy, producing generations of what Nketsia (2013) calls the "miscultured African". This African with Western/liberal ideas, is further described by Fanon (1952) as a person of a "Black skin, with white masks". African kingdoms

qadi or Muslim magistrates tried most cases which in the past had been tried by traditional law.

viii) In the ninth year of his reign, Idris made a pilgrimage to Mecca. He acquired a hotel in the Holy City for his people visiting Arabia on pilgrimage.

ix) The contacts which Idris made with the Islamic world, including Turkey, helped to increase the prestige of his empire. He himself was regarded with great respect throughout the Muslim world. Addressing himself to an embassy which the Turkish emperor sent to Bornu, Ibn Fartua, the Kanuri chronicler of Idris recorder the following words; O, my wise friends and companions; have you ever seen a king who is equal to our Lord [Idris] at such a moment?

x) Idris died when returning from an expedition in a marsh called Aloo. When he died;

a) He had expanded the Kanuri empire to its widest extent;

b) He had Islamised all aspects of life in the empire;

c) He had made his empire widely known and respected throughout the Muslim world in Africa, Asia and Turkey.

d) He left Kanuri at the peak of its power and prosperity. His reign coincided with the decline and fall of the Songhai Empire.

xi) The fame of Idris Alooma did not end with his death, but persisted down to the nineteenth century. The German explorer, Heinrich Barth, visiting Bornu in the mid-nineteenth century, testified to the greatness of Idris Alooma in the following words; " Altogether Idris Alooma appeared to have been an excellent prince, uniting in himself the most opposite qualities; warlike energy combined with mildness and intelligence; courage with circumspection and patience, severity with pious feeling" The achievement of Idris Alooma were such that he deserves to be counted among the great men in history.

ORGANISATION OF THE KANEM- BORNU EMPIRE

The Kanuri Empire lasted for over a thousand years. As can be expected, during this long period institutions of government underwent changes. However, the following may be regarded as an outline of how the vast empire was organised, when at the peak of its power.

Political Organisation

1. At the head of the central government was the Mai, or the king. He was regarded with such great awe that he did not show himself in public, expect on two great annual festivals. Otherwise he remained always hidden behind a curtain, even when receiving guests.

2. Next in importance was the Magira, or queen mother who controlled the domestic arrangements of the royal court. Some of these Magira became so powerful that they

had great influence over and occasionally vetoed the decisions of the Mai. Another influential person was the Gumsu, the first or eldest wife of the king.

3. In the early period of the Kanuri Empire, Bornu passed through a feudal phase, when the king ruled indirectly through feudal lords. These men were very powerful. They collected taxes in kind from their subjects, which were then passed to the imperial treasury.

4. The Mai was assisted in the administration of the empire by a state council of twelve men drawn from the royal family, as well as a number of great officials. When the Mai was weak the council of state had considerable power over the state affairs.

5. The empire was divided up into four provinces. These were;

(a) The North, headed by the Yerima;
(b) The South, headed by the Kaigama, who was also Commander-in-Chief;
(c) The East, headed by the Mestrema, who was also warden of the king's household
(d) The West, headed by the Galadima;
(e) These provincial rulers also served as leaders of the four main divisions of the imperial army.

Military Organisation

1. As noted above, for the purposes of political administration, the empire was divided up into four provinces. These divisions corresponded to the military divisions into which the imperial army was organised. The provincial governor was the Commander-in-Chief of the armed forces of his territory.

2. Under each provincial leader were a number of commanders, called the Kacella.

3. The Mai himself had a bodyguard.

4. In the reign of Idris Alooma the Mai introduced arms and military instructions from Turkey. The instructors helped to build up formidable armed forces for the empire.

Judicial Organisation

1. The imperial high court of justice was presided over by a chief justice who ranked second in the empire. He was known as the Mainin Kanendi. Working with the Mainin Kanendi were twelve other judges.

2. The third most important person in the realm was the Talba. His official duty was to keep the records of the high court.

3. Members of the high court were, as to be expected, very learned in the Koranic law. As such, they advised the Mai on most legal and religious matters.

4. Besides the high court, there were local courts in all the important towns in the empire. These courts were presided over by local judges versed in Islamic law and justice. People could appeal from the local courts to the high court of justice.

THE LAST PHASE OF THE KANEM- BORNU EMPIRE

The last phase of the Kanuri Empire was similar to that of Songhai, after Asika the Great. After Idris Alooma's death, there were three rulers who made some efforts to maintain the empire as the great Mai had left it. They did not have the ability however to improve on his work. These three rulers were Mai Muhammad 11 (1617-32), Mai Ibrahim (1632-9), and Mai Ali ibn Omar (1639-57)

1. Like Daud in Songhai, Mai Ali ibn Omar did his best to revive the declining power of the Kanuri Empire. He maintained Kanuri's international reputation and the diplomatic links which Idris Alooma had established. His work meant that the empire remained comparatively strong until the end of the eighteenth century.
2. Yet, throughout this period, Kanuri was not the powerful empire it had been under Idris Alooma. Although Bornu escaped the Moroccan invasion of the Western Sudan, she was affected by the general unrest and disorder which followed that invasion, and her trade suffered as a result.
3. Towards the close of the eighteenth century, Tuareg attacks on the empire became more frequent. Several vassal states began to assert their independence. The army was no longer strong. Indeed, the entire army of the last important Kanuri king, Mai Ahmad (1793-1810) perished in a military campaign against the Mandara in the south of the empire.
4. There were also internal conflicts in the eastern part of the empire. These divisions further weakened the empire, which reverted to the two separate states of Bornu and Kanem.
5. The old ties which linked the two sections of the empire did not, however, completely break apart. In 1808, when the Fulani jihadists attacked Bornu and drove the ruler Mai Ahmad from the capital N'gazargamu, in the east of the empire came across to the rescue of the west. His name was Muhammad Al-Kanemi (1776–1837) was an Islamic scholar, teacher, religious and political leader who advised and eventually supplanted the Sayfawa dynasty of the Kanem-Bornu Empire. In 1846, Al-Kanemi's son Umar I ibn Muhammad al-Amin became the sole ruler of Borno, an event which marked the end of the Sayfawa dynasty's eight hundred year rule. The current Shehu of Bornu, a traditional ruler whose seat remains in modern Borno State, Nigeria, is descended from Al-Kanemi.
6. Born to a Kanembu father and an Arab mother near Murzuk in what is today Libya, Al-Kanemi rose to prominence as a member of a rural religious community in the western provinces of what was then a much atrophied Borno Empire. The Fulani

jihadists, under Usman dan Fodio's banner tried to conquer Borno in 1808. They partly succeeded. They burnt the capital, N'Gazagarmo and defeated the main army of the mai of Borno. The latter called for the help of Al-Kanemi to repel his Fulani opponents. By planning, inspiration, and prayer, he attracted a following, especially from Shuwa Arab networks and Kanembu communities extending far outside Borno's borders. The mai (monarch), Dunama IX Lefiami rewarded the leader with control over a Bornu province on the Western march. Taking only the title "Shehu" ("Sheikh"), and eschewing the traditional offices, al-Kanemi gathered a powerful following, becoming both the voice of Bornu in negotiations with Sokoto, as well as a semi-independent ruler of a trade rich area with a powerful military. Dunama was deposed by his uncle in 1809, but the support of al-Kanemi brought him back to power in 1813.

(a) Muhammad Al-Kanemi had two advantages.

1. He was a great soldier, who could stand up against the Fulani commanders.
2. A devout Muslim, he adhered to a strict form of the religion. He could therefore argue convincingly against Uthman dan Fodio, his correspondence with dan Fodio's son, Muhammad Bello, he argued against the intentions of the Fulani, saying that, far from adulterating Islam, Bornu practised the purest form of the faith, and therefore needed no external reformer.

(b) When Mai Ahmad died, Al-Kanemi became the Sheik or Shehu of Bornu and ruled the territory until his own death in 1835. The new line he established replaced the Sefawa dynasty, which had lasted for about a thousand years.

(c) Under Al-Kanemi Bornu Empire came back to live again and the following achievements are attributed to the Shehu;

1. He carried out religious reforms, and made Islamic education compulsory in Bornu;
2. He built his own capital at Kukawa, which thus replaced N'gazargamu;
3. He made strenuous efforts but could not completely restore the frontiers of the ancient Kanem-Bornu Empire.

7. Al-Kanemi was succeeded by his son, Umar (1835-80), who had a very long reign. Umar I ibn Muhammad al-Amin or Umar of Borno (died 1881) was Shehu (Sheik) of the Kanem-Bornu Empire and son of Muhammad al-Amin al-Kanemi. Umar came to power at the death of his father in 1837 Umar did not match his father's vitality and gradually allowed the kingdom to be ruled by advisers (wazirs). Umar ruled from 1837 until November 1853 when he was deposed by his brother `Abd ar-Rahman ibn Muhammad al-Amin who became Shehu. The latter only reigned until 1854 when Umar reconquered his throne. Umar ruled as Shehu for a second time from September 1854 to 1880. Borno began to decline, as a result of administrative disorganisation, regional particularism, and attacks by the militant Ouaddai Empire to the east. The decline continued under Umar's sons, and in 1894 Rabih az-Zubayr, leading an invading army from eastern Sudan, conquered Borno.

(a) He tried hard to maintain and expand his kingdom, but he was not entirely successful.

(b) This was so because he encountered many difficulties. Chief among these were the following:

1. He had to keep in check provincial rulers who wanted to revive the Sefawa dynasty;
2. He was preoccupied with his own brother, Abd Al-Rahman, who was plotting to secure the throne for himself;

(c) He was also subject to the whims of some court officials who controlled his policy.

The Sefawa Dynasty

As the records show, the Sefawa dynasty started in about A.D. 774 and lasted until 1810, more than a millennium. It was one of the longest lasting dynasties in world history. Outlined below are some of the reasons which historians give when explaining this phenomemon.

Sayfawa dynasty or more properly Sefuwa dynasty is the name of the kings (or mai, as they called themselves) of the Kanem-Bornu Empire, centered first in Kanem in western Chad, and then, after 1380, in Borno (today north-eastern Nigeria). The dynasty was rooted in the Tubu expansion by the Kanembu.[1] The first ten kings present in the list in the Girgam are difficult to date and to identify. The dynasty, one of Africa's longest living, lost the throne in 1846. But we ought to consider these factors cautiously, since most of them, taken isolation, could apply to the history of other kingdoms and empires ruled by successive dynasties.

1. History shows that many dynasties fail to last long because of court intrigues, and disputes over the succession. The Kanuri empire was fortunate in that these occurred only very rarely in its long history.
2. It often happens that either because of natural causes, or because of an assassination, the rightful royal direct line dies out, and a new dynasty emerges. The Kanuri Empire was spared this misfortune.
3. The location of a kingdom may also help to explain the length of life of its dynasty. Unlike the empire of Ghana, Mali and Songhai, which flourished in the heart of the Western Sudan, and which therefore had to face the constant threat of aggressive neighbours, the Kanuri Empire, being in the extreme east of the territory, was not threatened by strong neighbours for a very long time. The relative tranquillity resulting from this helped the ruling dynasty to survive.
4. Added to the advantage just described was the fact that the Kanuri Empire was blessed with a number of outstanding rulers who enjoyed long reigns. Notable examples, as we have seen, were the following: Dunama I (53 years), Dunama II (38 years), Ali Ghaji (32 years), Idris Katakarmabe (22 years), Mai Muhammad (19 years).

and Idris Alooma (32 years). One effect of these long reigns was that the kings were able to consolidate their hold on the throne and prepare peacefully for their heirs to succeed them. There were very few attempts to replace these rulers, in spite of their long reigns because on the whole they concerned themselves with the development of the empire and the well-being of the people.

5. For a long time the vigorous trade of the empire meant that there was general prosperity. The people naturally attributed this situation to the kings who presided over them, and therefore saw no reason to overthrow their dynasty.

6. The fact that most of the rulers were closely involved with the cause of Islam and based their government on Islamic principles was also important. This practice, as we have seen in the case of other Sudanese empires, won for the empire and the rulers the respect and goodwill of the Islamic world.

EMERGENCE OF THE HAUSA AND THE FULANI

Hausa–Fulani is a term used to refer collectively to the Hausa and Fulani people of West Africa. The two are grouped together because since the Fulani War their histories have been largely intertwined within Nigeria. For example, when the Fulani took over Hausa city-state of Kano during the expansion of the Sokoto Caliphate, the new emirs ended up speaking the Hausa language instead of Fulfulde over the years. It must be noted though, that a significant portion of Fulani society are opposed to the use of this term which has been made popular most especially in recent times by its increased use in mass media.

The Hausa and Fulani together account for one out of Nigeria's three major ethnic groupings (alongside the Yoruba and Igbo (Ibo)). The Hausa and Fulani together, account for 29% of Nigeria's population. And to them dancing and tribal traditions are important. The Hausa land, before 1804, was made up of fourteen towns grouped into two. The first group of seven was called Hausa Bokwoi while the other group of seven was called Banza. The Fulani took over the political leadership of the Hausa or Habe states in the early 19th century. The Jihad that preceded this occupation was seen as religious as well as political.

The Fulanis settled in Hausa land and intermarried with the Hausa people after conquering them and this was how the name Hausa-Fulani came about. There are conflicting legends about the founding of the Hausa states. As is the case with several other early Muslim kingdoms of the Western Sudan, the later chroniclers whose accounts have reached us trace the origin of the Hausa to the Middle East, seat of Islam. The Kano Chronicle records that the people of Hausaland came originally from Baghdad. It is said that a certain Bayajidda emigrated from Baghdad to Kanem-Bornu. The precise date is not given. Though Bayajidda was privileged enough to marry the

daughter of the Kanuri ruler, later developments in the kingdom forced him to flee westwards.

He first stayed at Biram-ta-Gabas, where his wife bore him a son. He left his family there and came to Daura, where he was said to have performed a great feat, killing a sacred snake, "Sarki" which had for years deprived the people of water from a well, except on Fridays. In appreciation of this deed, the Queen of Daura married Bayajidda. Out of this union was born a son called Bawo. Later this Bawo-magari had seven children, who became the founders of the original Hausa states, called Hausa Bokwoi.

Original Hausa States

1. The original Hausa states are believed to have been named after the founders. These were:

(a) Biram and Daura, said to be the earliest settlements;
(b) Katsina and Zaria, founded by twin brothers respectively;
(c) Kano and Rano, founded by another set of twin brothers, and
(d) Gobir founded by the youngest of the seven brothers.

2. Although, as time wore on, these became independent, for mutual benefit each of the founders assumed special duties.

(a) Gobir, the youngest, became the Sarkin Yaki, or war leader. As his state lay to the north, he assumed the responsibility of warding off attacks of the Tuareg
(b) Kano and Rano supervised the rich indigo industry.
(c) Zaria became the Sarkin Bayi, responsible for obtaining slaves.
(d) Daura and Kastina controlled trade and commerce.
(e) However, as time went on, each became more and more independent, but they never completely broke off their ties of affinity.

Another Seven Hausa States

The Hausa traditions records that another set of seven states emerged sometime after the first seven were founded. These new states were collectively known as the Banza Bokwoi. They were; Kebbi, Zamfara, Nupe, Gwari, Yauri, Ilorin and Kwararafa (or Jukun). Some historians hold that these new states were not pure Hausa, but were founded by the offspring of pure Hausa Bokwoi kings and their concubines. But this theory has not been proved.

GROWTH AND ORGANISATION OF THE HAUSA AND THE FULANI

Each unit was a city state which comprised the walled capital and its immediate surroundings, and the neighbouring district consisting of villages and hamlets. Some

states grew stronger than the others. Among the leading states were Kano, Zaria and Kastina. By the eighteenth century Kastina had become not only a great centre of Islamic learning in Hausaland but also a great trade terminus. Visiting Hausaland in 1851, the German explorer, Heinrich Barth, recorded his impression as follows; Kastina during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries seems to have been the chief city of ... - Negroland and as well in commercial and political importance as other aspects. As could be expected, not all the fourteen states in Hausaland developed the same institutions. However, there were many which were common to most of the states.

THE PRE-COLONIAL POLITICAL ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA

Political Organisation/Political Administration

The Fulanis introduced centralised system of government after conquering the Hausa land. This gave rise to the Hausa- Fulani traditional or pre-colonial system being known as a centralised government. The caliphate was divided into emirates and each emirate was headed by an Emir. He had the responsibility of making laws, enforcing them and maintaining peace and order in his emirate. He was expected to administer the emirate in accordance with the provisions of the Islamic and sharia laws. He was believed to have the divine right to rule. However, each emir was assisted in the administration of the emirate by a number of advisers. These were:

Sarkin Fada: - The spokesman of the Emir and organiser of palace workers
Wazir: - The Prime Minister of the Emirate
Galadima: - The Administrator of the capital city
Madawaki- The commander and Head of the Emirate Army
Magaji: - Government Treasurer in-charge of the government treasury
Sarkin Dan Doka: - Inspector General of Police Force Called Dan Doka
Sarkin Ruwa: - Minister in-charge of Water Resources
Sarkin Pawa:- Head of Chairman of Butchers at the Abattoirs
Yari: - Chief Superintendent of Prisons in the Emirate

From the start, each Hausa state grew around the original settlement or principal trading centre of the area. As time wore on, many neighbouring smaller settlements came under the control of the ruler in the principal city, which thus became the capital and chief market centre for the area.

Largely because of political and trading rivalries, each principal city was, generally, walled for protection against external attacks. Together with the surrounding communities over which it had influence, the principal city became the centre of an independent city state similar to those which existed in ancient Greece. At the head of

the city state was the Sarki, or king, who had under him many subordinate local rulers who were, in some cases, members of the royal family.

As noted above, there was no uniform system of government throughout Hausaland. But there were common characteristics. Under the over-all authority of the Sarki, the machinery of state was run by a number of important state officials. Typical of the officials in a Hausa state were the following;

- The Galadima; he was often the heir but in some states he was always a eunuch; he was left in charge of the capital when the king was away from his seat of government.
- The Sarkin Fada, who was the chief official of the royal household sat with the Sarki to hear grievances.
- The Madawaki (in some places known as the Waziri); as Commander-in-Chief, he ranked next after the Sarki. In many ways his position was like that of the modern prime minister. He advised the king on many important state matters, including the appointment to important positions. He summoned councillors to meetings. He replied to the Sarki's address on ceremonial occasions.
- The Magaji; he was in charge of the state treasury.
- The Yari; he was in charge of prison affairs.

Other state officials were;

- The Sarkin Dogari, who was in charge of the king"s bodyguard, and
- The Sarkin Yan Doka, who headed the police, and kept in custody suspected criminals awaiting trial. He was also responsible for administering punishment to convicted persons.

Although each city state was independent, and there never really existed in Hausaland what today would be described as a federation, the city states developed certain ties which bound them together. This was found convenient for the purposes of collective protection against external enemies. The chronicles record that many states had priest-kings. When from the late sixteenth century Islam was firmly established, the Sarki exercised great powers. But they could not become absolute rulers, because in most states, like Kano, from the time of Rimfa, the council of state could check the Sarki's official actions.

Administration of Justice/Judicial Administration

The judicial administration of Hausa-Fulani was based on the Islamic legal system called Sharia. Sharia courts were established throughout the Emirates and each was headed by a trained Sharia Court Judge called Alkali. The Emir, despite this provision, remained the head who had the final say in deciding critical judgments. The chief justice

of the Sharia courts was called Grand Khadi. Village heads settled minor disputes in their villages but more serious and criminal cases were referred to the Emir for final and adequate settlement. As in modern times, justice was administered by a hierarchy of courts. The district head served as judge in minor cases. Appeals could be made to the superior courts of the king. Serious cases fall under the jurisdiction of the Sarki and his counsellors, advised by the chief Alkali. As the state came more and more under Islamic influence, the qadi (magistrate learned in the Islamic law) played an important role in the administration of justice.

1. Economic affairs

(a) Like other Sudanese kingdoms, the Hausa state benefited from the trans- Saharan trade, and trade with the southern kingdoms in the forest zone, notably the Yoruba and Benin states. There is evidence that they had trading links with Asante, Dagomba and Gonja, all in the present- day Republic of Ghana. In addition, the Hausa established prosperous trading links with Kanem- Bornu, with Mali and, later, with the Songhai Empire. The most important article of trade was salt, natron, kola nuts, hides and eunuchs. As the states developed, wealth was also derived from the sale of the products made from wood, metal and clay. There was also a brisk trade in slaves in Hausaland. Describing the crafts of the Hausa, Leo Africanus wrote: "The (Hausa) people are in general, very civilised. They have many weavers and shoe- makers who make shoes like those that the Romans used to wear; and these they export to Timbuctu and Gao"

(b) As well as the profits of trade, the states derived revenue from the different taxes which were levied. What Leo Africanus said of the state of Guangara which later became part of Kastina was true of all other states. He wrote; "He {the king} draws great revenue from dealing in goods and from commercial taxes". The following were the principal taxes;

i. Zakat or Zakka was income tax collected for charities;
ii. Jangali, or tax levied on livestock;
iii. Kharaj, or land tax;
iv. Jizyah (or gandu) was a capitation or poll tax levied on conquered states often paid in the form of slaves; and
v. Gaisua was tribute from vassal rulers.

In addition to these were special professional taxes.

(c) The revenue was used for social services and to maintain magnificent courts and other state institutions, including the army.

(d) The wealth of these states unfortunately attracted the envy of stronger neighbouring empires. Both Kastina and Kano fell into the hands of Bornu and Songhai for a period of time.

2. The Army

The different states set up and maintained strong armies. Most of the rulers could import superior weapons through their contacts with the merchants from the north and the Middle East. The armies included both foot-soldiers and cavalry. Speaking about the state of Guangara which later became part of Kastina, Leo Africanus said that state was "inhabited" by a great number of people who are governed by the king with more than 7,000 infantry armed with bows, and 500 foreign cavalry on call" About the middle of the fifteenth century Hausa armies started using muskets which were acquired through their contacts with Kanem-Bornu.

3. Religion/Official Religion

The Emir is the religious leader of his people, whose duty is to ensure that commandments of Allah are obeyed in his territory. This accounts for the great authority which was wielded by the Emirs and which made them such suitable rulers even under the British protectorate. The official religion was Islam and Koran was used as the holy book where all the teachings of religion were contained. Mohammed was seen as the founder of the religion. Some teachings that were contained in the Koran before the coming of the colonial administration include:

A good Moslem must fight a Jihad at least once in his life time. If such a person dies in the process he would go to paradise.

It is mandatory for all Moslems to perform hajj or pilgrimage to Mecca in the holy land at least once in the person's life time. Other Islamic injunctions include the following.

i) A good Moslem must not marry more than four wives.

ii) A good Moslem must abstain from drinking alcohol

iii) A good Moslem must fast during Ramadan period.

When Islam was introduced to Hausaland, at first its influence was limited to the royal courts. Islamic teaching affected many aspects of the life of the states though the indigenous religion remained untouched in many parts. As happened in other parts of the Western Sudan, Islam was introduced to Hausaland by zealous Muslim merchants. The Hausa themselves claim that Islam was introduced to them from Bornu by one Al-Maghili. Other traditions say that Al-Maghili came from Algeria. He had such a reputation that on request he wrote for the king of Kano the celebrated manual, the Obligations of Princes. It was not until the fourteenth century that organised Fulani missionaries from the empire of Mali started the work of conversion in Hausaland on a large scale. By the beginning of the fifteenth century the religion had taken a firm root, notably in the principal cities.

Islam did not spread to all parts of Hausaland at the same time. Some areas embraced the religion much earlier than others. Thus, according to the Kano Chronicle, one of the first Hausa rulers to embrace Islam was the king of the Kutumbawa dynasty, called Yaji (c. 1349-85). As Islam became established, scholars from Sankore (Timbuctu) introduced Islamic learning to Hausaland. Among the great Sankore scholars who either visited or lived for a time in Kano and influenced the history of Hausaland were the following;

- Al-Hajj Ahmad, who taught theology there towards the end of the fifteenth century;
- Makluf ibn Ali, a great lawyer and geographer, who visited Kastina and Kano in about 1500;
- Muhammad ibn Ahmad, who on arriving in Hausaland in about 1520, established a great reputation as a qadi (district magistrate) in Kastina.

SOME OUTSTANDING HAUSA RULERS

Muhammad Rimfa of Kano (1463-99)

The Kano Chronicle paid the following tribute to this great ruler of Kano; "He can have no equal in might, from the time of the founding of Kano, until it shall end.... Surely there was no Sarki more powerful than Rimfa" . Rimfa"s achievements show that these words were not far from the truth, even if at the time of writing the author did not know what the future had in store for Kano.

1. Rimfa made Kano invulnerable, by extending and strengthening the city walls. He built a magnificent palace which was named after him, the Dakin Rimfa.
2. To promote large-scale commercial activities, he built one of the greatest markets of the time, the kurmi market.
3. Knowing the importance of having a strong army both for internal peace-keeping and for offensive and defensive duties, he introduced the Dawakin Zaggi, an army formation in which foot-soldiers fought side by side with the horse soldiers, from whom the former took over. It was largely because of this formation that Rimfa was able to defeat his opponent in the sixteenth century wars with Kastina.
4. In the field of administration, Rimfa introduced the Council of Nine, called the Tara-ta-Kano, corresponding to Bornu's Council of Twelve. The Council included one eunuch who was in charge of the treasury. Eunuchs were also in charge of the town and palace guards and controlled the royal household.
5. His reforms extended to religion. He successfully wiped out all elements of paganism in Kano. He had the sacred tree in the city cut down, and he built a minaret on the site. Furthermore, he started the public celebration of the annual festival, the Id-al-Fitr, which follows Ramadan.
6. To add a touch of splendour to the court, he started the use of ostrich feather fans called Figinni on ceremonial occasions.

7. For these and many other things, Rimfa is regarded as the greatest ruler in Haus aland prior to the Fulani Jihad.

Kotal Kanta of Kebbi (1510- 45)

At the beginning of the sixteenth century, Kebbi was a vassal state of Askia the Great. In the second decade of the country this progressive state gained its independence from Songhai. This was the work of her great military leader, Kotal Kanta.

1. After Kanta had assisted Askia the Great to win Air, a quarrel broke out between them over the spoils. This resulted in a war (1515-16). Kanta inflicted a crushing defeat on Askia's men and gained his country"s independence. He then developed Surname into an important capital.
2. Following this victory, Kanta launched a successful attack on Air, Gobir, Kastina, Kano, Daura and Zaria.
3. He strengthened his army to protect and police his expanding kingdom.
4. How did he manage to control his expanding kingdom? Following the example of other Sudanese rulers, Kanta allowed the vassal states a considerable degree of self-rule and local autonomy, except for Zamfara and a couple of other states which proved too obstinate.
5. To offset the growing influence of the Fulani, Kanta refused to allow the Fulani immigrants to build houses in Kebbi. The Fulani resentment which this decision caused was later one of the reasons for the attack on Kebbi by the Fulani Jihadists.
6. The chronicles ranked Kanta among the greatest rulers in Hausaland. Indeed under Kanta there was a united Hausa empire. Even Muhammed Bello, Sultan of Sokoto, and son of Uthman dan Fodio, who had very little regard for ancient Kebbi, wrote the following words about Kebbi under Kanta; "No other kingdom in the past history of these {Hausa} countries ever equalled it {Kebbi} in power"

Talking about the garrison town of Kebbi, Sultan Bello added;" Their ruins, though it is about a hundred years since their cities were broken, surpass any we have ever seen". The credit for this was due to Kanta. He died at the ripe old age of eighty, after a successful reign lasting nearly forty years.

Queen Amina of Zaria

Like Kebbi, Zaria rose to prominence in the Western Sudan in the sixteenth century. The state owed much of its development to its ablest ruler, Queen Amina, daughter of King Bakwa, the founder of the capital of Zaria.

1. Tradition tells us that Amina became famous for building walled camps which later developed into important townships. One need not attribute to her the introduction of walled towns in Hausaland. But the fact that up to this day, ancient town walls in

Hausaland are called Ganuwar Amina, meaning "Amina's Walls"; would seem to indicate the importance of Amina's work.

2. The Kano Chronicle recorded the following about the queen; "At this time, Zaria, under Queen Amina, conquered all the towns as far as Kwararafa and Nupe. Every town paid tribute to her. The Sarkin Nupe sent forty eunuchs and ten thousand kolas to her. She first had eunuchs and kolas in Hausaland. Her conquest extended over thirty-four years. In her time the whole of the products of the west were brought to Hausaland". This passage points to several of Amina's achievements.

(a) She was a successful conqueror who annexed several territories to her kingdom.

(b) Her royal treasury was replenish by the tributes paid by her vassal states.

(c) During her reign trade from many parts of the Western Sudan was passing through Zaria.

3. Although much of what has been credited to Queen Amina may be legendary, the very fact that such legends exist would seem to indicate that she was a dynamic personality. In the words of Dr C. C. Ifemesia; "While making allowance for some exaggeration in the accounts (about Queen Amina), they nevertheless serve to indicate the power and influence which Zaria, under Sarauniya (Queen) Amina, wielded in the late sixteenth century Northern Nigeria".

4. The power of Zaria began to decline after the glorious reign of Queen Amina in the seventeenth century. This was as a result of the frequent invasions by the rulers of Kwararafa or Jukun. Indeed, the eighteenth century was a period of incessant inter-state warfare. This state of affairs weakened the Hausa states, and made it easier for the Fulani to conquest the territories in the first two decades of the nineteenth century.

FULANI CONQUEST OF HAUSALAND

Uthman Dan Fodio

Uthman, son of Fodio, was born in 1754 in Hausa state of Gobir. After receiving rudimentary Islamic education in his native Gobir. Dan Fodio continued his education at Agades, under the celebrated scholar, Jibril ibn Umar.

(a) Returning to his native land at the age of about twenty, dan Fodio set himself the task of teaching the pure form of Islam. He settled at Degel where he attracted many followers who joined him in his crusade for reviving the orthodox Islamic religion. Dan Fodio and his disciples launched an intensive campaign against various social evils, such as corruption in public life, economic injustice and adulterated Islamic practices.

(b) A renowned scholar, Dan Fodio was engaged by the ruler of Gobir to educate his children, among whom it is believed, was the future ruler, Yunfa.

(c) Dan Fodio became so popular as a result of his campaign against the pagan practices of the kings of Hausaland and the prevalent social and political injustices that the king of Gobir came to regard him as a dangerous man. The ruler, who was now Yunfa

himself, realised that unless dan Fodio was checked, he would cause dissension in the kingdom. Yunfa therefore withdrew all concessions granted to dan Fodio by his father, and indeed organised a plot which nearly resulted in the assassination of dan Fodio at Alkalawa, the capital of Gobir.

(d) In the face of real danger to his life, and following the example of the Prophet Muhammad in A.D. 622, Dan Fodio and his disciples, including his father, his brother, Abdullah, and his son Muhammed Bello, fleed from Degel to Gudu. This flight occurred on 21 February 1804, a date which, like the original Hijra of the Prophet, has since been observed in Northern Nigeria by Muslims with special reverence.

(e) Gudu now became the centre of dan Fodio's crusading activities. Thousands of followers flocked to him. A new era in Hausaland was in sight. Dan Fodio's disciples elected him Amir al-Muminin, meaning the "Commander of the Believer" and a holy war was declared on all pagans. This again copied the action taken by Muhammad at Medina, and was to lead to the creation of a new Muslim empire.

The Holy War (Othman Dan Fodio Jihad)

Tension rose to such a pitch between Yunfa of Gobir and dan Fodio that war became inevitable. Yunfa was the first to attack. His men followed dan Fodio to Gudu but were repulsed. This initial success, like that of the Prophet Muhammad in Medina, convinced Fodio's men that Allah was on their side. Soon after this Dan Fodio produced two important manifestoes, these urged his followers to believe in the rightness of the cause of Allah, and to fight the animism, the non-orthodox Islamic practices and the social and economic injustices which had plagued Hausaland for far too long.

Main Causes of Othman Dan Fodio Jihad

Many factors, some of which we have already noted in passing, combined to bring about the armed conflict between Dan Fodio and the rulers of the Hausa states, which was to result in the creation of a Fulani empire in Northern Nigeria. Some of these causes were religious, but others were political, economic and social.

(a) In the course of several centuries Islam in Hausaland had become corrupt. Animism and other pagan beliefs had deeply affected the conduct of Islam. The first aim of Dan Fodio's crusade was to bring about a lasting reform in religion and so restore the pure form of Islam in Hausaland. Conflict with the rulers of the land was inevitable since they were not prepared to allow such far-reaching reforms in their kingdoms.

(b) Because of their education and their commercial abilities, many Fulani in Hausaland felt resentful at having to serve under oppressive Hausa rulers, most of whom were illiterate, irreligious, and corrupt. Dan Fodio's attempts to bring about real reforms obviously aroused the bitter hostility of the powerful and autocratic rulers of the Hausa states.

himself, realised that unless dan Fodio was checked, he would cause dissension in the kingdom. Yunfa therefore withdrew all concessions granted to dan Fodio by his father, and indeed organised a plot which nearly resulted in the assassination of dan Fodio at Alkalawa, the capital of Gobir.

(d) In the face of real danger to his life, and following the example of the Prophet Muhammad in A.D. 622, Dan Fodio and his disciples, including his father, his brother, Abdullah, and his son Muhammed Bello, fleed from Degel to Gudu. This flight occurred on 21 February 1804, a date which, like the original Hijra of the Prophet, has since been observed in Northern Nigeria by Muslims with special reverence.

(e) Gudu now became the centre of dan Fodio's crusading activities. Thousands of followers flocked to him. A new era in Hausaland was in sight. Dan Fodio's disciples elected him Amir al-Muminin, meaning the "Commander of the Believer" and a holy war was declared on all pagans. This again copied the action taken by Muhammad at Medina, and was to lead to the creation of a new Muslim empire.

The Holy War (Othman Dan Fodio Jihad)

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(c) The practice of enslaving Muslims and selling them into slavery was common among Hausa rulers. They were also enlisted into "pagan" armies which fought against fellow Muslims. Dan Fodio considered this to be against the precepts of Islam.

(d) For centuries the Fulani and many ordinary Hausa citizens had been subjected to the oppressive rule and crippling taxation imposed by the Hausa rulers. This was another cause of discontent which made many Hausa prepared to join the Fulani in the struggle against their rulers.

(e) It may also be mentioned that many followers of dan Fodio were looking for an opportunity to gain body.

Course of the war

After the initial success of the Jihadists in Gudu, Dan Fodio's men carried the offensive into Gobir. They had some success, but were unable to take the capital. After repeated attacks, however, Alkawala fell to the Fulani invaders in 1808, and the ruler Yunfa was killed. Having gained a stronghold in Gobir, dan Fodio's generals embarked on a series of conquests in different directions.

(a) Enthusiasts from different Hausa states came to dan Fodio to offer their support; they took flags as signs of the reformer's authority and started jihads in their respective states. By 1809, the important Hausa states of Zaria, Kastina and Kano had all come under the control of the Fulani.

(b) The Fulani turned their attention to Bornu in the east, where they scored a temporary success. The Mai of Bornu appealed to a veteran soldier, Al-Kanemi, who succeeded in repulsing the Fulani.

(c) The Fulani swept southwards, and took Nupe and Adamawa.

(d) With the conquest of these southern states, the gates were now opened for a further southward thrust into Yorubaland. In 1817, the commander of the Oyo army, Kakanfo Afonja, who was local ruler of Ilorin, rebelled against his overlord, the Alafin of Oyo and invited the Fulani to come to his support. To the Fulani this was a most welcome invitation. Before long Afonja realised the mistake he had made. Having helped him to gain independence from the Alafin, the Fulani began to assert their authority in Ilorin. The Fulani scholar, Abdul Salami, Mallam Alimi's son, usurped the throne of Ilorin, and caliphate. Ilorin was to remain under the sphere of influence of Northern Nigeria until 1967, when the modern Republic of Nigeria was into twelve federal states, and Ilorin regained its identity as the Kwara State, free from the influence of Sokoto.

(e) Determine on pushing their conquest coastwards until they could "dip the Koran in the sea" the Fulani forces marched down into the heart of the Yoruba Empire of Oyo, which at that time was weakened by internal strife, until they were halted and repulsed by Ibadan in 1840.

1. Reasons for Rapid Success

Within a matter of two decades, as we have noted, the band of Fulani conquerors had annexed all the Hausa states, as well as Nupe, Adamawa, Ilorin and the western part of Bornu.

Reasons for the Success of the Othman-Dan Fodio Jihad

(a) The state of affairs in the Hausa states was one factor. As we explained earlier, before the Jihad, the Fulani and many of the ordinary Hausa elements in present-day Northern Nigeria had become discontented with their rulers. Thus the followers of dan Fodio, whether Fulani or Hausa, saw in the Jihad a golden opportunity to rid themselves of their unpopular rulers, and they therefore fought with great determination.

(b) While the Fulani were united in their dedication to a common cause, the Hausa states were, on the other hand, disunited and weakened by internecine wars. Thus, instead of presenting a united front against a common enemy, state after state had to face the ferocious invaders alone. Thus, when Gobir was attacked and Yunfa appealed to the other states for help, he received no response.

(c) The two manifestoes issued by dan Fodio calling upon the "faithful" to fight a relentless war against all forms of "paganism" in order to revive the true worship of Islam also encouraged the flagbearers and their followers to fight with ruthless determination.

(d) In the case of Ilorin, the treachery of Afonja opened the way for Fulani infiltration of Yorubaland.

The Consequences of the Fulani Conquest of Hausaland

The consequences of the Fulani conquest of the Hausa States in the first two decades of the nineteenth century were many and far-reaching.

(a) With the defeat of the Hausa States came the end of the Hausa dynasties. In their place emerged a powerful, united empire or caliphate, with its headquarters at Sokoto. The Sultan of Sokoto became not only the religious but also the political head of the numerous emirates which constituted Northern Nigeria down to the dawn of Nigeria's independence in 1960.

(b) The unification of the Hausa states meant the end of the rivalry which had crippled their progress in the eighteenth century.

(c) In atmosphere of peace which now prevailed throughout the caliphate, trade prospered, and the pure form of Islam spread. The standard of learning also increased.

(d) The success of the jihad in Hausaland was infectious. Many admirers took inspiration from dan Fodio and his son, Bello, and started reformist movements in their own countries, for example in Messina, Bornu, the empire of Samori Toure, etc.

(e) The solidarity of the united Fulani emirates has persisted to this day. Even though today the territories have been carved up to form separate states within the federation of modern Nigeria, the Hausa States still share a common cultural and religious history.

(f) From the time of their successful invasion of Yorubaland the ascendancy of the Fulani was to be a major factor in Nigerian history.
This was so even though they failed in their ultimate ambition of moving down to the coast until, as they put it, they "dipped the Koran in the sea". It was not by accident that, on attaining independence in 1960, the first Federal Prime Minister, Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa came from the former Fulani Empire in Northern Nigeria.

Work of Muhammad Bello

When dan Fodio became certain of success, he divided the territory he had conquered in two, he allotted one part with its capital at Gwandu, to his brother Abdullah, and the other part to his son Bello who established his new capital at Sokoto, but the western province continue to recognise the Sultan of Sokoto as liege-lord. Dan Fodio retired to live a life of scholarship and asceticism. After Fodio's death, his son was proclaimed Amir al-Muminim, or leader of the faithful, and thus he became both the political and spiritual leader of the new empire.

1. Muhammad Bello's first task was to cope with an internal insurrection and to repel external attacks.

(a) Internally, he successfully subdued a rebellion led by the Hausa scholar, Abd al-Salam, and also put down risings in Kebbi and Zamfara.

(b) Bello dealt swiftly with a threatened attack from the Tuareg in the north who gained the support of Gobir.

(c) At about the same time, a force from Bornu under the leadership of Al-Kanemi attacked the caliphate from the east. Bello was able to repulse the Bornu forces.

2. Having restored peace to the caliphate, Muhammad Bello next turned his attention to reforming many aspects of national life.

(a) To bring about unity, he merged all members of the caliphate, Hausa and Fulani alike, into one homogenous people. Every member of the community felt he belonged to the new empire and shared a common destiny with his fellow citizens. He gave equal opportunities in affairs of government to his kinsmen and the Hausa alike.

(b) To strengthen his own position, he reduced the powers of the Fulani military chiefs. Indeed, to ensure the peaceful administration of the caliphate, in some areas he replaced these military leaders with learned Mallams as local rulers.

(c) While remaining both the political and religious head of the caliphate, Muhammad Bello allowed a considerable degree of local autonomy and independence of action to the Emirs, the rulers of the constituent states of the empire. The emirs were to play an important role in Hausaland, especially during the period of the colonial rule in Northern Nigeria.

(d) Remembering the original objective of the jihad, Muhammad Bello set himself the task of reviving and encouraging Islamic learning. He himself took the lead in scholarship and produced many books of outstanding merit and of permanent value.

His correspondence with Al-Kanemi of Bornu, for example, is regarded as a particularly valuable history of the jihad.

(e) Bello also saw the need to build frontier walled cities, Ribats, as a protective measure against possible external attacks.

(f) To ensure their loyalty, Muhammad Bello required the emirs of the caliphate to pay him annual tributes at the time of the Muslim festivals. Individual office holders also paid tribute or gave presents to the Sultan of Sokoto. It was one of the greatest tributes to Muhammad Bello that, although the payment of tributes was voluntary, the emirs in fact competed among themselves as to who could give most, this being regarded as evidence of their support and loyalty to the Amir al-Muminin.

3. Muhammad Bello died in 1837, having ruled successfully the new Sokoto Caliphate for twenty years. Al Haji Sa'id, a Koranic official who served under Sultan Ali (1842-59), Muhammad Bello's son and successor, has paid his master's father the following tribute;

The Hausa country flourished greatly under his [Bello's] rule. He spread respect for learning, and scholars came from different countries. He was very solicitous for their welfare; whether they came from east, west, south or north. He spent much time in writing; every time he finished one of his works he made it known to the public and had them read it, and then set himself to writing another volume.

If anyone posed him a problem he made it at once the subject of a publication. If he found out that such and such persons were in disagreement {with him} on a point, he at once composed a treatise on it. He supported himself by the fruits of his work, without asking for upkeep from the public purse...He was sympathetic to the people and full of care for them, calm, patient, indifferent to the wealth of other men. A skilful administrator, he watched over the work of the qadis, quashed their judgements if these had been given under the influence of passion, never allowing them to grow slack in their work. Ruddy of complexion, tall, bald of head, wearing long and tufted beads; such was his appearance.

THE ORIGINS OF THE YÒRÙBÁ

The Yorubas form a large group united more by language than culture. The Yorubas trace their origin to Oduduwa who was the founder of the Yoruba kingdom. Oduduwa had seven sons who later founded the first seven kingdoms of the Yoruba land and these kingdoms were united under a central leader known as Alaafin of Oyo. Hatred, jealousy, etc made the first seven kingdoms to split into fourteen new kingdoms and the central leadership now changed from the Alaafin of Oyo to Ooni of Ife who is the spiritual Head of the Yoruba. Oyo is regarded as the political headquarters of the Yoruba and was the most developed kingdom in the Yoruba traditional society and its administration is accepted as a model or a representation of the Yoruba. The king in